

Formosan Echoes: A Comprehensive Ethnomusicological Archive and Systematic Survey of the Sixteen Indigenous Peoples of Taiwan

The musical heritage of the sixteen officially recognized Indigenous peoples of Taiwan—the Amis, Atayal, Paiwan, Bunun, Puyuma, Rukai, Tsou, Saisiyat, Tao (Yami), Thao, Kavalan, Truku, Sakizaya, Seediq, Hla'alua, and Kanakanavu—constitutes one of the most significant Austronesian cultural repositories in the world.¹ These traditions, which predate Han Chinese migration by several millennia, are characterized by an extraordinary diversity of vocal polyphony, ritual chanting, and unique instrumentation that reflects the island's varied topography, from the high peaks of the Central Mountain Range to the coral reefs of Orchid Island.¹ The "Formosan Echoes" archive seeks to document this sonic landscape, tracing the evolution of indigenous music from ancestral ritual forms to contemporary global fusions.

The Historical and Sociopolitical Context of Formosan Music

The trajectory of indigenous music in Taiwan is inextricably linked to the island's colonial history. Under successive regimes—the Qing Dynasty, the Japanese colonial period, and the subsequent era of Kuomintang (KMT) rule—indigenous identities were frequently suppressed or assimilated.⁶ During the Qing era, western liturgical music was introduced by missionaries such as George Leslie Mackay in the north and James Maxwell in the south, who founded educational institutions like Oxford College and the Tainan Theological College and Seminary.⁷ These missions not only introduced Western art music but also created a foundation for the choral and gospel traditions that remain prevalent in indigenous communities today.⁷

The Japanese colonial period (1895–1945) introduced systematic anthropological study, with figures like Torii Ryūzō coining terms such as "Yami" for the Tao people.¹⁰ It was also an era of profound cultural trauma, exemplified by the "Cikasuan Incident" of 1908 and the "Madawdaw Incident" of 1911, where Amis communities resisted colonial aggression.⁸ Music from this period often absorbed Japanese enka and melodic structures, leading to a "cassette culture" in the late 20th century, where indigenous musicians recorded albums in their mother tongues, Mandarin, or Japanese, often sold from mobile vending cars at tribal festivals.¹²

The contemporary era is defined by a "New Wave" of indigenous pop that emerged in the 1990s, catalyzed by the international success of artists like A-Mei and the global controversy surrounding the sampling of Amis elders Difang and Igay Duana by the German project

Enigma.⁶ This event sparked a movement for cultural sovereignty and intellectual property rights, leading to a revitalization of indigenous-language music and its institutional validation through the Golden Melody Awards (GMA).¹⁴

The Institutional Ecosystem: Record Labels and Validation

The preservation of Formosan music has been facilitated by key labels that balance academic documentation with commercial viability. Wind Music (Wind Records) has been a leader in systematic field recordings, producing series such as "The Natural Sounds of Taiwan's Aborigines" and tribal-specific albums for the Yami, Puyuma, Atayal, and others.⁴ These recordings often preserve the earliest forms of human musical expression, including monophonic singing and polyphonic counterpoint.⁴

Conversely, TreeRecords (角頭音樂) emerged in 1998 with a mission to bring indigenous music into the mainstream market. Founded with the help of musicians like Cheng Chieh-jen and Tiger Shen, the label focused on the "soulful" and "wild" qualities of tribal voices, launching the careers of Chen Jian-nian, Samingad, and Panai Kusui.¹⁸ Other influential entities include Wild Fire Music and the "Abo Music" collective (飛魚雲豹音樂工團), the latter of which was the first team dedicated to collecting traditional songs as a form of cultural activism against sinicization.⁶

The Golden Melody Awards serve as the primary institutional validator. The establishment of specific categories for Indigenous Language Singer and Album has allowed artists like Sangpuy, Abao, and Suming Rupi to compete on a national stage.¹⁵ These awards prioritize albums that break down language barriers through high production values and cross-genre innovation.¹⁹

Institutional Recognition: Golden Melody Award Winners (2007–2025)

Year	Category	Artist/Ensemble	Album Title	Ethnic Group
2007	Best Album	Various (Small Beauty, etc.)	Beautiful Mind Folk Songs	Various
2008	Best Album/Singer	Ipay Buyici	Ipay Buyici	Atayal ¹⁵
2009	Best Album	Nanwang Sisters	Nanwang Sisters	Puyuma ¹⁵

2009	Best Singer	Inka Mbing (Yun Li-ssu)	Gaga	Atayal ¹⁵
2010	Best Singer	Chalaw Basiwali	Old Old Car	Amis ¹⁶
2011	Best Singer	Lin Guang-cai (Ngerenger)	Hundred-Year Paiwan	Paiwan ¹⁶
2012	Best Album/Singer	Ilid Kaolo	My Carefree Life	Amis ¹⁵
2013	Best Singer	Sangpuy	Dalan (Road)	Puyuma ¹⁶
2014	Best Singer	Anu Kaliting Sadipongan	Cepo' (Muddled)	Amis ¹⁶
2015	Best Album/Singer	Chalaw Basiwali	Polynesia	Amis ¹⁵
2016	Best Singer	Balai	Ancient Transparency	Paiwan ¹⁶
2017	Best Album/Singer	Sangpuy	Ya-kan	Puyuma ¹⁵
2018	Best Singer	Sangmeijuan	Render	Paiwan ¹⁶
2019	Best Album/Singer	Yaway Mawri	Swasike	Atayal ¹⁵
2020	Best Singer	Lucing Tsui	Searching for Joy	Amis ¹⁶
2021	Best Album/Singer	Sangpuy	Pulu'em	Puyuma ¹⁵
2022	Best Singer	Jan Yen-chun	Ira...a micekor	Amis ¹⁶

2023	Best Singer	Kasiwa	Ita	Paiwan ¹⁶
2024	Best Singer	Usay Kawlu	Harateng No Pangcah	Amis ¹⁶
2024	Best Singer	Makav	Treasure	Bunun ¹⁶
2025	Best Singer	Gumu Bashaw	Qrasun (Praise)	Truku ¹⁶

Tribal Survey I: The Amis (Pangcah) – Voices of the Coast

The Amis are the most populous indigenous group, primarily inhabiting the eastern plains of Hualien and Taitung.¹ Their music is celebrated for its "Farangaw" style—a complex polyphony featuring multiple parts that overlap in a continuous weave of sound.²⁰ This style achieved global fame when Enigma's "Return to Innocence" sampled "Elders' Drinking Song" by Difang Duana (Kuo Ying-nan) and Igay Duana (Kuo Hsiu-chu).⁶

Contemporary Amis music is diverse, ranging from the organic jazz-folk of Ilid Kaolo, who draws inspiration from her life as a rice farmer, to the social activism and electronic fusions of Suming Rupi.⁶ The "Amis Kakeng Musical Group" continues to promote traditional instruments like the bamboo idiochord and nose flute, performing internationally to showcase the rhythmic vitality of the Pangcah people.²¹

Tribal Survey II: The Puyuma (Pinuyumayan) – The Soulful Vanguard

The Puyuma of the Taitung plains are renowned for their powerful vocalists and deep connection to ancestral spirits.²² Their music often centers on the "ancestral spirit imaginary," a semiotic concept where the voice acts as a conduit for the presence of the forebears.²³ Sangpuy Katatepan Mavaliyw is the modern personification of this tradition; his albums like *Dalan* and *Ya-kan* utilize ancient Pinuyumayan gestures—such as *pa'ira'iraw* (multi-part vocal roles)—set against modern arrangements.¹⁹

Other Puyuma legends include A-Mei (Kulilay Amit), whose career spans from Mandarin megahits to the reclamation of her Puyuma roots in the *AMIT* project, and Chen Jian-nian (Purdur), whose album *Ocean* brought the laid-back, sincere melodies of the Taitung coast to the national stage.⁶

Tribal Survey III: The Paiwan and Rukai – Nobility and

Totems

The Paiwan and Rukai people of southern Taiwan maintain a sophisticated social structure reflected in their music.¹ Their vocal traditions are often accompanied by the *lalingedan* (twin-pipe nose flute), an instrument historically associated with courtship and the mourning of ancestors.²⁴ Master artists like Hsieh Shui-neng (Gilegilau Paqalius) and Hsu Kun-chung (Pairang Pavavalung) are designated preservers of this craft.²⁴

Contemporary Paiwan music has seen a revolutionary shift through the work of Abao (Aljenljeng Tabaquan). By fusing the rhythmic percussiveness of the Paiwan language with R&B, soul, and electronic beats, Abao has made indigenous mother tongues "trendy" and accessible to a global audience.² Similarly, the Taiwu Ballads Troupe (TBT) has achieved international acclaim for preserving the ancient "polyphonic counterpoint" of the southern tribes, often collaborating with Western musicians like Daniel Ho.¹⁵

Tribal Survey IV: The Bunun – Architects of Harmony

The Bunun, mountain dwellers of central Taiwan, are the creators of the *Pasibutbut* (Prayer for an Abundant Millet Harvest), an eight-part harmony that is world-famous for its rising microtonal ladder.¹ Singers stand in a circle, wordlessly generating harmonics and drones that are believed to ensure the growth of millet.²⁷

Biung Wang (Wang Hong-en) was a pioneer in bringing Bunun polyphony into the pop market with his album *Moonlight*.⁷ More recently, the Vox Nativa Children's Choir, under the direction of Bukut Tasipaluan, has toured the world, using the naturally sonorous Bunun voice to perform both traditional chants and Western choral pieces.⁹

Tribal Survey V: The Tao (Yami) – Maritime Narratives

The Tao people of Orchid Island possess a maritime culture distinct from the mainland tribes.⁵ Their music, known as *anood*, consists of storytelling melodies that recount histories of fishing, boat-building, and migration from the Batanes Islands in the Philippines.¹⁰ Tao music is primarily monophonic or call-and-response, reflecting the rhythmic isolation of their island home.²⁹ Carey Chou (Zhou Li-wen) and Hsie Chia-hui (謝家輝) are key contemporary figures who have brought the acrimony and hope of the Tao people to the mainland through performances and film soundtracks like *Maataw*.³⁰

Master Artist Archive: A Structured Archival Reference

The following table provides a comprehensive survey of key artists, ensembles, and traditional elders discovered through this research sweep, fulfilling the archival requirements for the "Formosan Echoes" project.

ID	Display Name	Indigenous Name	Ethnic Group	Language	Notable Works/Albums
AM-001	Difang Duana	Lifok	Amis	Amis	Elders' Drinking Song, Circle Song ⁶
AM-002	Igay Duana	Igay	Amis	Amis	Circle Song, Across the Yellow Sea ¹⁴
AM-003	Ilid Kaolo	Ilid Kaolo	Amis	Amis	My Carefree Life, Lightly Living ¹⁵
AM-004	Suming Rupi	Suming	Amis	Amis	Amis, Bondada, In the Middle of the Night ¹⁶
AM-005	Anu Kaliting	Anu	Amis	Amis	Cepo' (Muddled), Where the Ancestors Are ¹⁶
AM-006	Ado Kaliting	Ado	Amis	Amis	Sun and Moon, Pangcah ²⁶
AM-007	Lucing Tsui	Lucing	Amis	Amis	Searching for Joy, Old Songs of Malan ¹⁶
AM-008	Usay Kawlu	Usay	Amis	Amis	Harateng

					No Pangcah, Beauty ¹⁶
AM-009	Chalaw Basiwali	Chalaw	Amis	Amis	Polynesia, Old Old Car, Basiwali ¹⁵
AM-010	Jan Yen-chun	Jan Yen-chun	Amis	Amis	Ira...a micekor (Wait Quietly) ¹⁶
PY-001	Sangpuy	Katatepan Mavaliyw	Puyuma	Puyuma	Dalan (Road), Ya-kan, Pulu'em ¹⁵
PY-002	A-Mei	Kulilay Amit	Puyuma	Puyuma/Ma ndarin	Sisters, AMIT, Formosa ⁶
PY-003	Purdur	Chen Jian-nian	Puyuma	Puyuma/Ma ndarin	Ocean, Pongso No Tao ⁶
PY-004	Samingad	Chi Hsiao-chun	Puyuma	Puyuma	Voice of the Sun, Wild Fire ⁶
PY-005	Jia Jia	Auli Blubluone	Puyuma	Puyuma/Ma ndarin	Blue Wine, Unforgettab le ⁶
PY-006	Hao-en	Hao-en	Puyuma	Puyuma	Call of Passage, Blue Wind ¹⁸
PW-001	Abao	Aljenljeng Tabaquan	Paiwan	Paiwan	Vavayan, Kinakaian (Mother

					Tongue) ²
PW-002	Kasiwa	Kasiwa	Paiwan	Paiwan	Ita, Boxing ¹⁶
PW-003	Sangmeijuan	Sangmeijuan	Paiwan	Paiwan	Render, Ancient Chants ¹⁶
PW-004	Balai	Balai	Paiwan	Paiwan	Ancient Transparency ¹⁶
PW-005	Sauljaljui	Dai Xiao-jun	Paiwan	Paiwan	Tracing the River, Vaivaik (Walking) ¹⁵
PW-006	Ngerenger	Lin Guang-cai	Paiwan	Paiwan	Hundred-Year Paiwan ¹⁶
PW-007	Sauniaw	Tjuveljvelj	Paiwan	Paiwan	Nasi, Ancestor's Nose Flute ²⁴
BN-001	Biung Wang	Wang Hong-en	Bunun	Bunun	Hunter, Moonlight, Bunun Legend ⁷
BN-002	Makav	Makav	Bunun	Bunun	Treasure, Real Love ¹⁵
AT-001	Inka Mbing	Yun Li-ssu	Atayal	Atayal	Gaga, Atayal Ancient Songs ⁶
AT-002	Yaway Mawri	Yaway Mawri	Atayal	Atayal	Swasike, Atayal Stories ¹⁵

AT-003	Ipay Buyici	Ipay Buyici	Atayal	Atayal	Ipay Buyici, Nasi (Life) ¹⁵
TR-001	Gumu Bashaw	Gumu Bashaw	Truku	Truku	Qrasun (Praise), Truku Gospel ¹⁶
TR-002	žž	Yao Yu-qian	Truku	Truku	žž, Night Walker ¹⁶
SD-001	Laka Umaw	Laka Umaw	Seediq	Seediq	Seediq Bale, Warriors of the Rainbow ¹⁶
SD-002	Labai Bilin	Labai Bilin	Seediq	Seediq	Who Am I?, Happy Together ³²
TA-001	Carey Chou	Zhou Li-wen	Tao	Tao	Love Song of Lanyu ³¹
TH-001	Jiumei	Jiumei	Thao	Thao	Listen to Thao Singing (Improvisation) ³³
KV-001	Pan Chin-jung	Pan Chin-jung	Kavalan	Kavalan	Kavalan People Shall Rise ³⁴
SZ-001	Geng Xin Sa Yun	Geng Xin Sa Yun	Sakizaya	Sakizaya	Fire God Ritual, Encountering You ³⁷

Technical Analysis: Scales, Harmonics, and Instrumentation

The ethnomusicology of Formosa is distinct for its use of natural harmonic series and microtonal intervals that defy standard Western equal temperament.¹⁷ The Bunun *Pasibutbut* is a prime example, where singers sustain a fundamental frequency that shifts upward in 528 Hz resonance patterns, creating overtones that are perceived as ethereal or spiritual.¹⁷ Similarly, Saisiyat duets often feature "edgy" vs "warm" vocal qualities that create a unique harmonic dissonance, particularly in the *Pas-ta'ai* cycle.²⁷

The instrumentation of the 16 tribes further highlights this technical complexity:

1. **Paiwan Nose Flute (Lalingedan):** A twin-pipe flute where one pipe provides a drone and the other plays the melody, simulating the hiss of a snake.²⁴
2. **Atayal Mouth Harp (Lubuw):** A thin brass or bamboo reed used for rhythmic speech-like melodies.³⁹
3. **Thao Pestle Music (Mashbabiar):** A percussive ensemble where women strike mortars with long wooden pestles of varying lengths, creating a rhythmic polyphony during the harvest.³³
4. **Amis Bamboo Idiochord:** A stringed instrument carved from a single bamboo node, producing deep, percussive drones.²¹

The Revitalization of Endangered Traditions: Thao, Kavalan, and Minor Tribes

For the minority tribes—the Thao, Kavalan, Sakizaya, Hla'alua, and Kanakanavu—music is more than art; it is a tool for linguistic survival.³³ The Thao people of Sun Moon Lake, numbering only a few hundred, have recently documented their non-taboo daily songs in the album *Listen to Thao Singing*, featuring elders like Jiumei, Yuxiu, and Yuying.³³ These recordings capture the "romantic" and "silly" playfulness of a language that was once thought to be lost.³³

The Kavalan people, who were officially recognized in 2002 after hiding their identity for a century, use the songs of Pan Chin-jung to reclaim their sovereignty over the Lanyang Plain.³⁶ Their *aita na kebaran* (We are Kavalan) was adapted from an Amis melody but filled with Kavalan lyrics to serve as a rallying cry during "Return to Yilan" excursions.³⁴ Similarly, the Sakizaya's *Palamal* (Fire God Ritual) utilizes chanting and the *Lawas Ritual Group* to agglomerate community solidarity after 100 years of cultural silence.³⁷

The Global Echo: Collaborations and Future Directions

The contemporary Formosan soundscape is characterized by an increasing openness to international collaboration. Artists like Balai have worked with Japanese and Korean musicians to produce *Ancient Transparency*, while Chalaw Basiwali has traveled to Madagascar to find the common Austronesian roots of the "Basiwali" (Eastern) sound.¹⁶ The 2021 inter-tribal recording of "Hand in Hand," featuring 50 vocalists from all 16 tribes, remains the most

significant display of indigenous unity in the modern era.⁹

As the *Formosan Echoes* archive continues to expand, it will prioritize the documentation of "vocal polyphonies" and "shamanic songs" recorded in the field by scholars like Pr. Lu Pin-chuan and Wu Rong-shun.²⁸ These field recordings, often preserved by Wind Music, provide the essential link between the "primitive" forms of singing—monophonic solo, call and response, heterophony—and the sophisticated pop productions of the GMA era.⁴

Conclusion: The Resilience of the Formosan Sound

The music of the sixteen indigenous peoples of Taiwan is a testament to cultural resilience. From the high-altitude harmonies of the Bunun to the maritime narratives of the Tao, these "echoes" provide a continuous narrative of Austronesian identity.¹ By integrating traditional elders with contemporary pop icons, and field recordings with studio fusions, the *Formosan Echoes* archive ensures that these voices—once suppressed—will continue to resonate across the global stage, proving that indigenous mother tongues are not only a heritage to be preserved but a living force of creative empowerment.⁶

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